

Vakhtang Licheli
Ivane Javakhishvili Tbilisi State University

The Stages of Development of the Local Script in Georgia of the Pagan Age

Introduction

The issue of the origin and evolution of a script, representing an integral and paramount phenomenon of the culture, constitutes a subject of interest not only for grammatologists, linguists or scientists of various interdisciplinary branches of knowledge but it attracts wide publicity as well. The reason is simple and apparent – the script is the most significant feature of the civilization.

An absolutely special interest of the Georgians towards their script has been clearly disclosed in the phrase from the early medieval historical chronicle ‘The Life of Pharnavaz’: ‘(He) created the Georgian literacy’. At the same time, it is widely known that there are different opinions concerning the chronology of the creation of this part of ‘The Life of Kartli’ (For interesting analysis of the Georgian written sources).¹

A comprehensive information pertaining the issue in question could be found in the work of Ot. Lordkipanidze² and ff. The Stele of Davati, on the one hand, is the graphic illustration of the Georgians’ ceaseless attitude to their own script and, on the other hand, it is a good proof verifying the priority of the archaeological materials in the study of the script history. All the more so because the analysis of one and the same written source should be repeatedly and rather scrupulously carried out. Correspondingly, systematization of the archaeological contexts and their primary interpretation are only objectives of the work under discussion.

¹ St. H. Rapp Jr., *Re Sasanian World through Georgian Eyes. Caucasia and the Iranian Commonwealth in the Late Antique Georgian Literature*, Ashgate 2014.

² Ot. Lordkipanidze, *At the Dawn of the Ancient Georgian Civilization*, Tbilisi 2002, p. 248.

Samples of the Local Script in Georgia of the Pagan Age

According to the archaeological materials discovered on the territory of Colchis and Iberia, three stages could be distinguished in the history of the pagan script:

1. Paleo-Georgian.
2. Transitional.
3. Proto-Georgian.

The Paleo-Georgian Script

In connection with the topic in question, in the recent years the finds of the Grakliani Gora site, where the inscription dated from the 10th century BC has been discovered, occupy a special place in the Georgian archaeological materials. Because of the exceptional significance of this site, we offer a concise review of its archaeological novelties:

The Archaeological Context of Grakliani Gora

Grakliani Gora is a multilayered site, where remains of eleven periods are evidenced, starting from the Paleolithic period (app. 1 800 000 years) up to the Early Christian Period (4th-5th cc AD). The site consists of two parts: a necropolis and a settlement.

The Necropolis. 360 burials were excavated covering periods from the Early Bronze (4th millennium BC) up to 4th-5th cc AD. From the point of the topography, the necropolis is divided into two main parts – the burials dated from the Bronze Age were mainly located on terraces I and II, while the ones dated from the Achaemenid or the Post-Achaemenid Ages – on terraces III and IV (pl.1). For instance, burial N I-19-6 dated from the end of the 2nd millennium BC excavated in 2019 on the first terrace.

Besides, burial N III – 19-4 excavated on terrace III was also remarkable. It was dated from the mid-4th century BC and contained extremely interesting inventory made of silver: a silver forehead band, silver bracelets, a silver spoon, a bronze arch-like fibula, gold earrings, and a long-necked pitcher (pl.1,2). Together with a male deceased, lying on his right side, there was buried his horse as well. An example of small-sized bronze figurine discovered in the burial of a child was also remarkable. It represents an ear-cleaner in the shape of a figure of a pregnant woman. Her left hand touches her ear in such a way that accentuates her readiness to listen (pl. 2.1). There are different types of such hygienic items in Grakliani graves (pl. 3.1), as well as accessories made of various materials (3.1 a - b).

The settlement. Architectural remains characterized with functional diversity (dwelling, household, cult buildings, workshops) were mostly dated from the 2nd-1st millennia BC. Earlier buildings were destroyed in the course of construction of these very buildings.

Up to now 17 buildings have been revealed only on terraces III and IV. The buildings dated from the turn of the 2nd and 1st millennia are of special interest in the context of the discovery of the inscriptions in the shrine dated from this very period.

One more intellectual novelty – introduction of the unified system of weight (the mass unit, corresponding to 363 g, named by me 'Iberian mina' as it was discovered in Kartli/Iberia) – was evidenced at Grakliani in the same period (2nd-1st millennia BC). Each weight found at the Grakliani site represents multiplied version of 363 g3. Of unique discoveries dated from the 10th

³ V. Licheli, 'Intellectual Innovations in Georgia (11th-9th Centuries BC). Excavations at Grakliani Hill, Brill,

century BC a clay idol with two merlons is remarkable. It was evidenced in the shrine, where the inscription was found. No zoomorphic or anthropomorphic features were fully expressed in it, except of one important detail, underlining features of female gender – breasts expressed by circles, under which a circular hole is visible in the abdominal area of the idol (pl. 4.1-2).

Supposedly, sacrificed items were placed on a ritual oven by means of this idol. No artefacts analogous to this item in question have ever been found, though, plenty of figures with double protome or double heads, dating from the various periods, are known in the archaeology of the Near East and Europe (e.g. zoomorphic figures with double heads found in Beth Yerah.^{4,5} Roumanian anthropomorphic representations are good examples of the early European figurines.^{6,7}

Cult, production, and public buildings dated from the later period (5th-4th cc BC) also belong to the sphere of special interest since up to now Grakliani represents the only site in Caucasian Iberia, where their existence is evidenced 8 9). Of the artefacts dated from this period, a mould for production of personal ornaments is of interest (pl. 5-1,5-2), as well as another mould for production of local clay bowls imitating Achaemenid silver ones (pl.5.3-2). In addition, noteworthy is a local imitation of Greek pottery (decorated with a nail-like pattern - pl.5.3.1), which was produced in Kartli (possibly, at Grakliani?). These items represent unique artefacts giving insight into the ancient history of Georgia as they manifest an absolutely new aspect in the cultural and economic contacts of Kartli/Caucasian Iberia.

The Results of the Interdisciplinary analysis:

1. The results of the palynological analysis of the Grakliani material: Remains characteristic of summer (aquatic plants) were discovered in samples collected from 25 burial pitchers proving that the interment of the deceased was performed in summer. Remains characteristic of mead – an alcoholic liquid received owing to fermentation of honey – were identified in 9 burial pitchers. No signs characteristic of aquatic plants were defined in these vessels. It means that the deceased were buried in winter. As for fabric, usage of linen and cotton fabric was proved in the majority of cases.

2. The Paleoclimat (7th-4th cc BC):

Supposedly, the total amount of annual precipitation was higher compared to that of nowadays. Both composition of wood vegetation and the spectral complex of herbaceous

2020', In: *Ancient Civilizations from Scythia to Siberia* 26 (2020), pp. 350-361.

⁴ R. Amiran, 'Reexamination of a cult- and art-object from Beth Yerah'. In: *Assays in Ancient Civilization Presented to Helene J. Kantor*, ed. By A. Leonard, Jr and B. B. Williams, Re Oriental Institute of the University of Chicago, *Studies in Ancient Oriental Civilization* N 47, Chicago-Illinois, 1989, pp. 31-38;

⁵ P. Beck, 'Notes on the Style and Iconography of the Chalcolithic Hoard from Nahal Mishmar', In: *Assays in Ancient Civilization Presented to Helene J. Kantor*, ed. by A. Leonard, Jr and B. B. Williams, Re Oriental Institute of the University of Chicago, *Studies in Ancient Oriental Civilization* N 47, Chicago-Illinois 1989, pp. 39-54.

⁶ S. Hansen, 'Figurines in Pietrele: Copper Age Ideology'. In: *Documenta Praehistorica* XXXVIII (2011), pp. 1-13.

⁷ M. Gimbutas, *Civilizacia velikoi bogini: mir drevnei evropi*, Moskva, 2006, p. 360.

⁸ V. Licheli, 'The second stage of the Grakliani Culture'. In: *Wonders Lost and Found. A celebration of the archaeological work of Professor Michael Vickers*, edited by Nicholas Sekunda, Archaeopress Archaeology, Ashmolean Museum, University of Oxford 2020, pp. 48-58.

⁹ V. Litcheli, 'Kommentaren zum archäologischen Kontext des Grakliani Gora von 5.-4. Jahrhunderten v. Chr.' In: *Georgica. Zeitschrift für Kultur, Sprache und Gesschichte Georgiens und Kaukasiens* 38, Jahrgang, Jena 2017, pp. 41-58.

plants prove correctness of this assumption. Alder and beech can grow in woods only in damp climatic conditions. Fern margarita and adder's tongue (*Ophioglossum vulgatum*) that were evidenced in the burial materials of Grakliani can grow in conditions of the analogous damp climate. Existence of flour (*Pseudoschizaeae*, *Triticum*, *Humulus lupulus*) was evidenced in the oven excavated at Grakliani.

3. The mineralogical and petrographic analyses of the pottery found at Grakliani classified products of imported and local pottery. From this point of view, local imitations of the Greek vessels, which are completely unusual for ceramic products of Kartli/Caucasian Iberia, acquire particular significance. Among them are: a lagynos-like, buff fabric pitcher adorned with local traditional décor, retaining only its Greek shape; an imitation of Greek black-glazed plates, adorned with a 'nail-like' ornamentation adopted from the Greek pottery of the Post-Achaemenid/Hellenistic period.

4. Palaeobotanical researches proved the existence of wheat (*Triticum Aestivum*) and millet (*Panicum Miliaceum L.*).

5. Palaeozoological materials: domesticated animals: a) cattle – cow/bull, horse and pig, goat, and sheep; b) dog; wild animals (game): a) boar, b) bear, c) red deer.

6. The results of anthropological analysis of the Grakliani material: a) the most widespread disease – osteochondrosis (in the age of 50-55 years); b) tumours; c) traces of trepanation are proved.

a) The Inscription Discovered at Grakliani

This sample of the writing system was discovered in Kartli, at Grakliani Gora. Archaeological excavations of the Achaemenid temple were carried out on terrace III of Grakliani Gora in the course of several years. The main building that was evidenced there represents a construction dated from the 5th-4th cc BC. The building in question was burned and ruined in the second half of the 4th century BC.

In 2015, excavations started with the purpose to investigate an area to the north of the Achaemenid temple that was found on terrace III. The preparation performed in squares F8-F9 resulted into discovery of a building (6 m x 2,7 m). A massive clay construction, a sanctuary with sherds of various sizes scattered on it, attached to the western wall of the building, was unearthed. Nearby were found carbonized grains of millet and wheat.

A small-sized clay altar (0,55 x 0,40 m) displaced/lowered from its original location was revealed in a distance of 0,2 m from the western wall, in the central part of the building. A double protomae clay figurine was applied to the northern part of the shrine. It became the second case of representation of double-protomae ram figurines at this site.

The altar was placed on a base carefully made of clay, having an oval-shaped frontal line in its plan. Burnt poles (dm – 15 cm) evidenced in both eastern and western corners of the frontal side serve as a proof that an additional clay construction was installed for this shrine in the interior of the temple. Correspondingly, it could be assumed that the altar was endowed with an extra special importance.

An inscription ("B") runs on the frontal part of the base. The revealed length of the script reaches 80 cm, while its height is 7 cm. The script flows effortlessly, lines are drawn

skillfully (pl. 6.1). It is evident that the carver of the inscription was not performing it for the first time. It could be regarded as evidence in favor of the possible existence of some other inscriptions dated from slightly earlier periods or their synchronous ones. The best laboratories of the world (the Radiocarbon Dating Beta Laboratory based in Miami, the Groningen University laboratory, the Zürich laboratory for Radiocarbon Dating) performed the C14 analysis, calculating one and the same date – the 11th-10th cc BC. Most likely, the content of the inscription bears religious/cult character since it was written on the base of the altar located in the shrine. However, regardless of the content of the Grakliani inscription, it is apparent that it represents the only monument of the writing system performed in this style which has never been evidenced not only in Georgia but in the whole Caucasus. It is extremely important that it is stationary i.e. it was executed by the natives; it served to the society, inhabiting the territory of Eastern Georgia 3 000 years ago. It could be assumed that starting from the epoch in question, the writing system, existing ceaselessly and being used on the territory of Georgia, has undergone all the ways of natural development and refinement.

The Inscription "A", which was partly preserved on western altar, was strongly damaged on the Northern wall of the shrine (pl. 6.2 – 6.3).

What could be added at this stage of the study of the Grakliani inscription? Already in 1960, discussing the Armazi script, G. Tsereteli wrote about the genesis of the Georgian script: 'The Armazi script appeared to be an intermediary via which the Georgian alphabet found its direct ties with the Aramean' [G. Tsereteli. The Ancient Georgian Inscriptions in Palestine, Tbilisi, 1960, p. 51 (Footnote)]. Notwithstanding the fact that he meant the script of the Christian Age, this trend regarding pagan scripts actually, in light of the recent finds, became even more pronounced. In addition, 'The Chronicle of Cognition' should be doubtlessly mentioned here. In fact, it conveys the same idea ('But priests' script originates from the Jewish and Chaldean ones and therefore letters of the priests' script resemble the Jewish and Chaldean ones' (in detail see below).

Now it appears that this fact, i.e. the issue of origin of the Georgian script has a prehistory starting from the 11th-10th cc BC. The graphic analysis of the Grakliani Gora script proves that we are dealing with a standard phenomenon characteristic of the period in question. In accordance with this standard phenomenon, in the 2nd-1st millennia BC all advanced states adopted the simplest type of script – the Aramean. This phenomenon and, generally, adoption of scripts is a commonly recognized fact.

For instance, it is proved that the tribes that were using Indo-European dialects were not creators of their scripts. They were borrowing a writing system created on the basis of other languages. Correspondingly, a syllabic linear 'B' script was borrowed from the other source by the Mycenaean Greeks to create their own one ... Later the Greeks adopted 'the consonant-syllabic' version of the ancient Semitic script – the Phoenician, which was transformed into an alphabetic system of the script. The Hittites borrowed literacy from the old Chaldean version of the cuneiform script which was widespread in North Syria from the beginning of the 2nd millennium BC.¹⁰

Presumably, the population of Kartli, the bearer of 'the Samtavro culture', occurred in the turmoil of civilizations' junction and, in the complete accordance with the common standards, also adopted the graphic option of the Aramaic script, adjusting it to requirements

¹⁰ T. Gamkrelidze, V. Ivanov, *Indo-European and Indo-Europeans*, Tbilisi 1984, pp. 887-889 (in Russian).

of the Georgian language. Along with the general tendency, the adoption is proved by graphic similarity, existing between the Grakliani and Aramaic signs.

Most likely, in light of new data, the analogies, existing in the Samtavro and Colchian archaeological cultures (e.g. the pottery with the zoomorphic handles, open-socketed spearheads¹¹) are noteworthy, since they could be indicators of the ways of appearance of this form of civilization in Kartli.

At present Prof. Federico Mario Fales from the Udine university works on the problem of decoding the inscription in question. He considers that he is familiar with all signs of the „B“ script, however, because of the regional and chronological discrepancies (representing an ordinary phenomenon) additional analysis is needed to define their phonetic equivalence (personal communication). In 2018, one more short inscription written with the letters of the „B“ script (Pl.) was discovered on the stone platter (in the bothros, pl. 7. 1-4). From my point of view (based on experiment), the content of the inscription deals with the capacity of the stone platter, corresponding to the amount of wheat that is equal to two, Iberian minas¹² (i.e. 2x363 = 726 g).

b) The Transitional Period

The only gap in this system of development is the transitional period, i.e. the 9th-5th cc BC. No signs of script have been discovered in the archaeological materials of this period yet. But the whole context of the material culture exposes such a high level of advancement of the Colchian (Grave goods from Tsaishi Collective grave can be mentioned as an example of a high level of development¹²) and Iberian (Narekvavi settlement discoveries can be mentioned as an evidence of high level of local development¹³) societies that expectations for discovery of inscriptions dated from this period are feasible.

c) Proto-Georgian Script

The next stage in the history of writing system of the pagan period starts from the 4th century BC. The archaeological context to be discussed later, is preceded by a tenacious indication preserved in the 11th century Georgian chronicle "Kartlis tsxovreba" ('Life of Georgia'): 'Parnavaz was the first king of Kartli descended from Kartlos, who extended the Georgian language, and no more was a different language spoken in Kartli except Georgian and it was then he created Georgian literacy¹⁴'.

This record and an exceptionally accomplished form of the Early Christian Georgian written sources became the basis for investigations carried out in the course of many years to study the existence of the Georgian literacy in the Pagan Age. These investigations were crowned by I. Javakhishvili's statement that 'most likely the Georgians had their own literacy already in the 7th century BC.¹⁴

However, it should be also marked here that 'Chronicles of Cognition' by Catholicos Patriarch of Georgia Anton II existed already in 1822, indicating that 'The Georgians were not illiterate prior Pharnavaz, they were using writing system of elders, in other words, of

¹¹ N. Akhvlediani, 'Issues of the investigation of Late Bronze-Early Iron Ages in Southern Caucasus', In: *Issues of the History and Archaeology of Georgia and Caucasus*, pp. 275-282, 2012.

¹² R. Papuashvili, T. Eosebua, L. Jikia, I. Papuashvili, *Re tsaishi cemetery*, Tbilisi-Zugdidi 2015, pp. 9-39.

¹³ R. Davlianidze, V. Sadradze, *Narekvavi settlement and necropolis*, Tbilisi 1993.

¹⁴ I. Javakhishvili, *Paleography*, Tbilisi 1949, pp. 272-273.

high priests or elders or chief priests of pagan shrine, they were monks worshipping idols, sacrificing themselves to god in the name of their nation. And their script is our Khutsuri alphabet that originated from the Hebrew and Chaldean scripts. Therefore letters of the Khutsuri script are similar to those of the Hebrew and Chaldean ones.¹⁵ This note is acquiring especial importance due to the discovery of the inscription at Grakliani Gora.

Survey of this topic seems redundant since plenty of scholarly valuable works have been dedicated to the Georgian script.^{16 17 18 19 20}

The Archaeological Context

There are certain groups of ceramic artefacts (pithoi, amphorae, and tiles) obtained at various archaeological sites dated from the 4th c. BC – 4th c. AD on the territory of Georgia (Colchis, Iberia) that are adorned with signs of diverse shapes and carved on them prior their baking (pl. 8.1-4)

Topography and Chronology of Proto-Georgian writing signs.

Location	4 th c. BC	4 th – 3 rd cc. BC	3 rd – 2 nd cc. BC	2 nd – 1 st cc. BC	2 nd – 1 st cc. BC – 1 st – 2 nd cc. A.D.	1 st – 2 nd cc. AD	2 nd – 3 rd cc. AD	3 rd – 4 th cc. AD
Dablagomi	⌘	⌘, ⌘, ⌘ ⌘, ⌘, ⌘, ⌘	⌘					
Dapnari	⌘	⌘						
Supsa-Natanebi basin			⌘, +, ⌘					
Nokalakevi			⌘					
Nanepish-Chale			⌘					
Vani			⌘, ⌘, ⌘ ⌘, ⌘, ⌘	⌘, ⌘, ⌘ ⌘, ⌘, ⌘				

¹⁵ G. Sharadze, 'Teimuraz Bagrationi, Life', Tbilisi 1972, pp. 122-127. Cited from R. Pataridze's *Re Georgian Asomtavruli*, Tbilisi 1980, p. 17.

¹⁶ R. Pataridze, *Re Georgian Asomtavruli*, Tbilisi 1980.

¹⁷ R. Pataridze, cited work, p. 14.

¹⁸ R. Pataridze, *Re Georgian Literacy*, Tbilisi 1988.

¹⁹ T. Chkhenkeli, *Re Georgian Alphabet: Opinions*, Gantiadi N5, 1989, p. 272 and ff.

²⁰ T. Gamkrelidze, *Re Alphabetic System of Writing and the Georgian Script*, Tbilisi 1989.

Mtisdziri			ღ					
Sarkine-Grdzeli Mindori					↑, x, √, ζ, +			
Uplistsikhe				↑				
Bagineti						x, √, ↑, √, √, √		
Samtavro				+ √, √, √, √			√, √, √, √	
Mtskheta Necropolis						↑, √, √, √, √		
Mogvtakari						√, √, √, √		
Karsniskhevi							√, √, √, √	
Armaziskhevi							√, √, √, √	

These writing signs are divided into two groups (And it is a noteworthy fact!): the pottery shapes with the Greek inscription and the ones with ‘uncertain signs’ as they are named in the scientific literature.

The most important detail deserves to be particularly underlined: these signs are found on the artefacts obtained during archaeological excavations. Correspondingly, it means that these materials represent documentally, actually, materially existing data, which regardless of kind of its interpretation, constitute an integral, and, presumably, a main part of the Georgian civilization of the Classical period.

In other words, we are dealing with the fact of existence of the writing signs, rather than its possible version. The essence of the so-called ‘uncertain’ signs’ was subjected to scholarly debates only in 1989²¹. The exceptional importance of the issue in question gives grounds for presentation of a concise survey of the logical sequences, the comprehensive version of which, illustrating the essence of these signs, has already been published²²

Some nuances are noteworthy:

a) First of all the provenance of the ceramic products with ‘the signs’ carved on them was defined. From this point of view, a thorough study was performed and it was concluded that the three main pottery shapes on which the signs were most frequently encountered – pithoi,

amphorae, and tiles – were made locally. In all cases the signs were deeply carved prior their baking. These facts serve as evidence in favor of point of view that the signs under discussion were drawn by artisans inhabiting the territory of present-day Georgia.

b) The signs are carved in each single pottery shape in accordance with a completely determined system, namely:

Pithoi. In all cases the signs are drawn on a shoulder (under a neck).

Amphorae. The signs are drawn on shoulders or necks of Colchian amphorae (Amphorae had not been manufactured in Iberia).

Tiles. As a rule, in Colchis and Iberia, the signs were placed on outer surfaces (except of rare cases). Stamps could be encountered very rarely on the tiles of the Colchian production, too.

Thus, the signs on all the three pottery shapes made in Colchis and Iberia are placed on those very segments, on which letters are evidenced in other regions, i.e. on the segments that occur into the visual field. Carving of graphemes on the pottery was a widespread phenomenon in the Ancient World, therefore there is no necessity for dwelling on it.

In case of juxtaposition of the previously mentioned data, a following factual casus becomes evident: when signs with recognizable essence are placed on the pottery, for instance on the tile, and when they are affiliated to the Greek alphabet, correspondingly, they are regarded to be letters and this conclusion is doubtless.

The other part of the signs is drawn:

on exactly the same product,
on exactly the same segment,
with exactly the same function,
with exactly the same number on each single shape,
at exactly the same time.

However, they have been regarded as ‘uncertain’ only for the reason that they are not matching the Greek alphabet. Therefore, absolutely logically, a following question requires an answer: If both groups are characterized with absolutely identical features (except of the outlines) then why could not it be assumed that the signs of the ‘uncertain’ group belong to a certain alphabet?

The answer could be only positive since otherwise the logic requires rejecting of the attribution of the Greek signs to the alphabet/writing system as well. Graphic analysis of the discovered signs, their topography and functional significance imply that the signs carved on the Colchian and Iberian pottery dated from the 4th century BC – 4th century AD represent letters of the Proto-Georgian script. Correspondingly, an assumption proposed by Georgian scientists – that the Georgians had their own writing (alphabetical?) system starting from the 4th century BC - has been eventually confirmed. My point of view has been shared by the famous German specialist Fähnrich, H.²³ This is that very script that was introduced by Pharnavaz.

This relative table of the writing systems also confirms this fact:

Proto-Georgian writing and relative table of ancient writings

²¹ V. Licheli, ‘The Dablagomi letter-signs’, *Matsne, Series of History, Art Studies, Ethnography, and Archaeology*, Tbilisi 1989, pp. 30-430.

²² V. Licheli, *Re Problems of the Colchian and Iberian Cultures*, Tbilisi 2001, pp. 5-28.

²³ H. Fähnrich, *Die ältesten georgischen Inschriften*, Leiden, Boston 2013, Brill, pp. 221; 232.

Phoenician		Archaic Greek		Ancient Semitic		Proto-Georgian		Carian		Likhian South Arabic		Sites where Proto-Georgian signs were discovered
Sign	Phonetic Value	Sign	Phonetic Value	Sign	Phonetic Value	Sign	Phonetic Value	Sign	Phonetic Value	Sign	Phonetic Value	
𐤀	ʾ	Δ Δ	α	𐤁	𐤁	𐤂	α?	𐤃	α	𐤄	𐤄	Svetitskhoveli
𐤅	ב	𐤆	ב	𐤇	ב	𐤈?		𐤉	ב	𐤊	ב	Vani
𐤋	ג	𐤌	ג	𐤍	ג	𐤎?		𐤏	ג	𐤐	ג	Karsniskhevi
𐤑	ד	Δ	ד	𐤒	ד	𐤓		Δ	ד	𐤔	ד	Dablagomi
𐤕	ה	𐤖	ה	𐤗	ה	𐤘		𐤙	ה	𐤚	ה	Vani
𐤛	ו			𐤜	ו	𐤝		𐤞	ו	𐤟	ו	Bagineti
𐤡	ז	𐤢	ז	𐤣	ז	𐤤?		𐤥	ז	𐤦	ז	Dablagomi
𐤨	ח	𐤩	ח, ֿ	𐤪	ח	𐤫		𐤬	ח	𐤭	ח	Nanepish Chale
𐤮	ט	𐤯	ט	𐤰	ט	𐤱		𐤲	ט	𐤳	ט	
𐤴	י	𐤵	י	𐤶	י	𐤷				𐤸	י	Mtisdziri
𐤺	כ	𐤻	כ	𐤼	כ	𐤽				𐤾	כ	Dablagomi
𐤿	ל	𐐀	ל	𐐁	ל	𐐂		𐐃	ל	𐐄	ל	Mtskheta
𐐆	מ	𐐇	מ	𐐈	מ	𐐉		𐐊	מ	𐐋	מ	Vani
𐐌	נ	𐐍	נ	𐐎	נ	𐐏		𐐐	נ	𐐑	נ	Dapnari
𐐒	ס			𐐓	ס					𐐔	ס	
𐐕	ץ	𐐖	ץ	𐐗	ץ			𐐘	ץ	𐐙	ץ	
												Dapnari

𐌁	𐌂	𐌃	𐌄	𐌅	𐌆			𐌇	𐌈	𐌉		
𐌊	𐌋	𐌌	𐌍	𐌎	𐌏			𐌐	𐌑	𐌒	𐌓	
𐌔	𐌕			𐌖	𐌗	𐌘		𐌙	𐌚	𐌛	𐌜	Dablagomi
𐌝	𐌞	𐌟	𐌠	𐌡	𐌢	𐌣	𐌤	𐌥	𐌦	𐌧	𐌨	
𐌩	𐌪	𐌫	𐌬	𐌭	𐌮			𐌯	𐌰	𐌱	𐌲	
		𐌳	𐌴					𐌵	𐌶	𐌷	𐌸	
								𐌹	𐌺	𐌻		Mtskheta
								𐌽	𐌾	𐌿		
								𐍂		𐍃	𐍄	

In the course of juxtaposition of the signs carved on the pottery dated from the 4th century BC–4th century AD that was discovered on the territory of Georgia with any alphabet with which it has aforementioned parallels, it appears that the complex of these signs, i.e. the system, does not resemble any alphabet (or, generally, any writing system) familiar to us up to now.

Therefore, it is obvious that we are dealing with a unity of signs, the system, unknown up to now.

And eventually, in case if the aforementioned logical discussion causes any kind of skepticism, then an answer should be received on the following question:

If we do not consider these letter-signs as the parts of the writing system, then how could be explained the phenomenon when all artisans scattered on the whole territory of Colchis and Iberia were compelled to use only a small number of strictly defined signs in the course of the whole eight hundred years?

There could be only one logical answer – artisans were using letters of their own, local writing system that frequently were bearers of numeric values, completely corresponding to the traditions of the writing systems dated from the Classical period.

Conclusion

This fact, i.e. existence of the proto-Georgian script, is not unexpected since development of both Colchis and Kartli as well as the dynamics of the existing relations undoubtedly meant certain progress expressed in the establishment of a writing system. The previously mentioned archaeological context fully proved this possibility.

As for the phonetic significance of these signs, it became possible to define some of them (for instance, if we consider these signs by means of the Zanuri writing, then ‘an arrow’ should denote sound ‘o’ or ‘v’; while a ‘double arrow’ – the sound ‘dz’. And, if the sign denoting a coniferous tree,

could develop in accordance with the principle of acrophony, in such a case 'n' is its equivalent²⁴ (in detail see: V. Licheli, *Problems of Culture of Colchis and Iberia*, Tbilisi, 2001, pp. 25-27).

Up to now the only inscription, performed by means of the writing system in question, has been found at the Dablagomi site. According to the accounts of 1970-1972, it was discovered in burial N 17. It is clear that this burial, accidentally discovered by local residents at Dablagomi, in which a pitcher with an inscription was found, is of special importance. The burial inventory included: 1. a pitcher with a handle made manually. Four letters:     are scratched out on it. 2. Pieces of a bronze bracelet made of plain wire; 3. The Colchian tetri, worth of a triobol (dm – 1,4 cm). The burial is dated from the 4th-3rd cc BC.

It is noteworthy that the pitcher dated from the 4th-3rd centuries BC, on which four letters (   ) are scratched, was impromptu made of unbaked clay. From my point of view, here a name of a deity or deceased was scratched. G. Kvashilava reads it as 'Tekus-ike-a' corresponding to an affection version or diminutive one of a male name 'Tekus-a'.²⁵

In addition, it should be marked that a certain affinity exists between the signs of the proto-Georgian and Early Christian Asomtavruli Georgian writing systems.

Several graphic analogies to the Asomtavruli script:

The Asomtavruli  – the Proto-Georgian 

The Asomtavruli  – the Proto-Georgian 

The Asomtavruli  – the Proto-Georgian 

This identity represents a proof of reservation of local script tradition, its hereditary and logical development. It constitutes the evidence for the statement that by the commencement of the Early Christian Age in Ancient Georgia the basis for the existence of the local script had already been established. Therefore this reality absolutely excluded any kinds of interference of any outer influences in the process of invention of the Asomtavruli writing system.

Thus, relying upon the previously mentioned data, it is concluded that the local pagan script was differentiated in the following three stages:

Paleo-Georgian – 10th c BC
 Transitional – 9th-5th cc BC
 Proto-Georgian – 4th c BC – 4th c AD

The Christian Georgian script was introduced from the 5th century AD. On the grounds of this writing system many masterpieces of the Georgian literacy were created, eventually crowned by Shota Rustaveli's 'The Man in the Panther's Skin.

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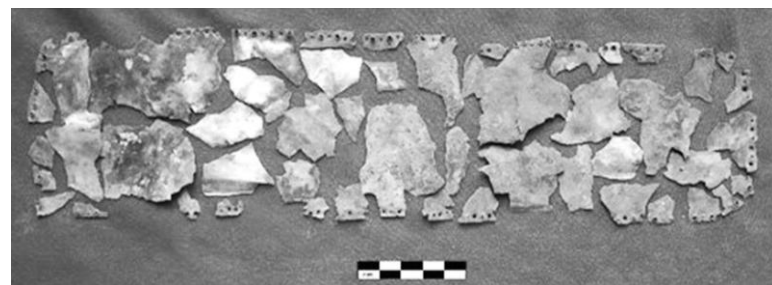
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²⁴ G. Kvashilava, 'On the Decoding of the Inscription Discovered on the Dablagomi Pitcher and the Ancient Linear Sign from Jumiti Stone Found in Georgia', *Kartvelology*, Tbilisi 2017, pp. 50-67.

²⁵ V. Licheli, *Problems of Culture of Colchis and Iberia*, Tbilisi 2001, pp. 25-27.



Grakliani Gora



1.2. Grave N 19-4. silver jewelry, first half of 4th c



2.1 Bronze Sculpture



3.1 a. Disc, electrum, 4th c BC



3.1 b Egyptian scarab, 4th c BC



3.1. ear-cleaner, bone, 4th c BC



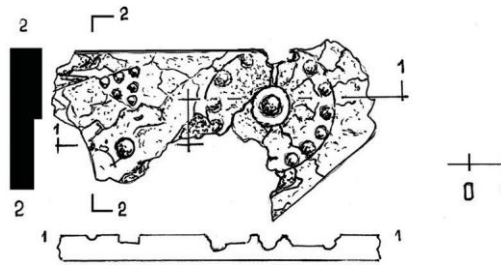
4.1 Excavations of Idol



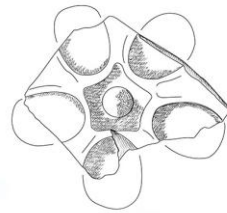
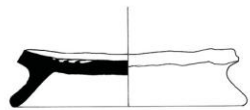
4.2 Idol



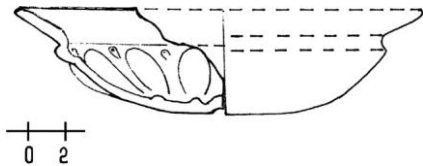
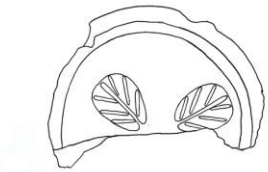
5.1 a mould for production of personal ornaments



5.2 a mould



5.3 1-2 a local imitation of Greek pottery and mould for production of local clay bowls imitating Achaemenid silver ones



5-1a. Achaemenid clay cup, 4th c BC



6.1 B inscription



6.2 A inscription



6.3 damaged letters of A inscription on the Northern wall of the shrine



Bothros with stone plate.



Stone plate with inscription, 10th c BC



Stone plate from bothros.



Inscription on the stone plate.



Proto-Georgian sign on the pithos.



8.4 Dablagomi inscription

Signs of Paleo-Georgian script,
10th c BC

Signs of Proto-Georgian script,
4th c BC-4th c AD